

CATION

leader, ready for the 21st century

WINNING LINE-UP
Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan (8th from left), Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa (6th from left) and winners of the Best Colleges Awards and Best Universities Awards at the India Today Education Conclave 2024

Photographs by **ARUN KUMAR**

> "WE WILL BRING IN A NEW NATIONAL TESTING AGENCY BY THE TIME THE EXAMS HAPPEN NEXT YEAR. I AM HOPEFUL IT WILL HAVE A BIG IMPACT ON COMPETITIVE EXAMS"
>
> **DHARMENDRA PRADHAN**
> *Union Minister of Education*

Raj Chengappa, Pradhan said, "From 2014 to 2024, the budget for higher education saw a 78 per cent increase, while school education experienced a 40 per cent rise." Pradhan also spoke about the PM Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI) school upgrade scheme launched in 2022. The PM SHRI scheme aims to redevelop 14,500 existing schools into 'model schools' embodying the essence of the NEP.

Calling the NEP "a philosophical document for the entire globe" and highlighting three priority areas—competence, language and technology—Pradhan said, "The new education system is transitioning from being degree-centric to focusing on competence. India is a nation of natural innovators, but the talent pool should not be judged solely based on degrees." He further said, "Skill-based education, research and entrepreneurship need to be encouraged. We must create a culture that transitions from degrees to competency".

Talking about the criticism faced by the government over the leak of examination papers and other inconsistencies in the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test Undergraduate (NEET-UG), conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA), the minister assured the gathered audience that the Centre will introduce a new and reformed NTA by next year to establish a "zero-error" competitive examination system.

The conclave also saw the announcement of two sets of awards—the India Today Best Colleges Awards 2024 for institutes across 14 streams and the India Today Best Universities Awards 2024. It was a fitting finale of the day. ■